

'I think he is definitely cleared.'

'But Mr Clement, who can it be? Lucius was not popular, I know, but I don't think he had any real enemies. Not—not that kind of enemy.'

I shook my head.

'It's a mystery.'

I thought wonderingly of Miss Marple's seven suspects. Who could they be?

After I took leave of Anne, I proceeded to put a certain plan of mine into action.

I returned from Old Hall by way of a private path. When I reached the stile, I retraced my steps, and choosing a place where I fancied the undergrowth showed signs of being disturbed, I turned aside from the path and forced my way through the bushes. The wood was a thick one, with a good deal of tangled undergrowth. My progress was not very fast, and I suddenly became aware that someone else was moving among the bushes not very far from me. As I paused irresolutely, Lawrence Redding came into sight. He was carrying a large stone.

I suppose I must have looked surprised, for he suddenly burst out laughing.

'No,' he said, 'it's not a clue; it's a peace offering.'

'A peace offering?'

'Well, a basis for negotiations, shall we say? I want an excuse for calling on your neighbour, Miss Marple, and I have been told that there is nothing she likes so much as a nice bit of rock or stone for the Japanese gardens she makes.'

'Quite true,' I said. 'But what do you want with the old lady?'

'Just this. If there was anything to be seen yesterday evening Miss Marple saw it. I don't mean anything necessarily connected with the crime—that she would think connected with the crime. I mean some *outré* or bizarre incident, some simple little happening that might give us a clue to the truth. Something that she wouldn't think worthwhile mentioning to the police.'

'It's possible, I suppose.'

'It's worth trying anyhow. Clement, I'm going to get to the bottom of this business. For Anne's sake, if nobody else's. And I haven't any too much confidence in Slack—he's a zealous fellow, but zeal can't really take the place of brains.'

'I see,' I said, 'that you are that favourite character of fiction, the amateur detective. I don't know that they really hold their own with the professional in real life.'

He looked at me shrewdly and suddenly laughed.

'What are you doing in the wood, padre?'

I had the grace to blush.

'Just the same as I am doing, I dare swear. We've got the same idea, haven't we? *How did the murderer come to the study?* First way, along the lane and through the gate; second way, by the front door; third way—is there a third way? My idea was to see if there were any sign of the bushes being disturbed or broken anywhere near the wall of the Vicarage garden.'

'That was just my idea,' I admitted.

'I hadn't really got down to the job, though,' continued Lawrence, 'because it occurred to me that I'd like to see Miss Marple first, to make quite sure that no one did pass along the lane yesterday evening while we were in the studio.'

I shook my head.

'She was quite positive that nobody did.'

'Yes, nobody whom she would call anybody—sounds mad, but you see what I mean. But there might have been someone like a postman or a milkman or a butcher's boy—someone whose presence would be so natural that you wouldn't think of mentioning it.'

'You've been reading G. K. Chesterton,' I said, and Lawrence did not deny it.

'But don't you think there's just possibly something in the idea?'

'Well, I suppose there might be,' I admitted.

Without further ado we made our way to Miss Marple's. She was working in the garden, and called out to us as we climbed over the stile.

'You see,' murmured Lawrence, 'she sees everybody.'

She received us very graciously, and was much pleased with Lawrence's immense rock, which he presented with all due solemnity.

'It's very thoughtful of you, Mr Redding. Very thoughtful indeed.'

Emboldened by this, Lawrence embarked on his questions. Miss Marple listened attentively.

'Yes, I see what you mean, and I quite agree; it is the sort of thing no one mentions or bothers to mention. But I can assure you that there was nothing of the kind. Nothing whatever.'

'You are sure, Miss Marple?'

'Quite sure.'

'Did you see anyone go by the path into the wood that afternoon?' I asked. 'Or come from it?'

'Oh! yes, quite a number of people. Dr Stone and Miss Cram went that way—it's the nearest way to the barrow for them. That was a little after two o'clock. And Dr Stone returned that way—as you know, Mr Redding, since he joined you and Mrs Protheroe.'

'By the way,' I said, 'that shot—the one you heard, Miss Marple. Mr Redding and Mrs Protheroe must have heard it too.'

I looked inquiringly at Lawrence.

'Yes,' he said frowning. 'I believe I did hear some shots. Weren't there one or two shots?'

'I only heard one,' said Miss Marple.

'It's only the vaguest impression in my mind,' said Lawrence. 'Curse it all, I wish I could remember. If only I'd known. You see I was so completely taken up with—with—'

He paused, embarrassed.

I gave a tactful cough. Miss Marple, with a touch of prudishness, changed the subject.

'Inspector Slack has been trying to get me to say whether I heard the shot after Mr Redding and Mrs Protheroe had left the studio or before. I've had to confess that I really could not say definitely, but I have the impression—which is growing stronger the more I think about it—that it was after.'

'Then that less the celebrated Dr Stone out anyway,' said Lawrence with a laugh. 'Not that there has ever been the slightest reason why he should be suspected of shooting poor old Protheroe.'

'Ah!' said Miss Marple. 'But I always find it prudent to suspect everybody just a little. What I say is, you really never *know*, do you?'

This was typical of Miss Marple. I asked Lawrence if he agreed with her about the shot.

He showed me into the drawing room, switching on the electric lights, since the blinds were down.

'A very sad business all this,' I said.

'Yes, sir.'

His voice was cold and respectful.

I looked at him. What feelings were at work under that impassive demeanour. Were there things that he knew and could have told us? There is nothing so inhuman as the mask of the good servant.

'Is there anything more, sir?'

'Was there just a hint of anxiety to be gone behind that correct expression?'

'There's nothing more,' I said.

I had a very short time to wait before Anne Protheroe came to me. We discussed and settled a few arrangements and then:

'What a wonderfully kind man Dr Haydock is,' she exclaimed.

'Haydock is the best fellow I know.'

'He has been amazingly kind to me. But he looks very sad, doesn't he?'

It had never occurred to me to think of Haydock as sad. I turned the idea over in my mind.

'I don't think I've ever noticed it,' I said at last.

'I never have, until today.'

'One's own troubles sharpen one's eyes sometimes,' I said.

'That's very true.'

She paused and then said:

'Mr Clement, there's one thing I absolutely *cannot* make out. If my husband was shot immediately after I left him, how was it that I didn't hear the shot?'

'They have reason to believe that the shot was fired later.'

'But the 6.20 on the note.'

'Was possibly added by a different hand—the murderer's.'

Her cheek paled.

'How horrible!'

'It didn't strike you that the date was not in his handwriting?'

'None of it looked like his handwriting.'

There was some truth in this observation. It was a somewhat illegible scrawl, not so precise as Protheroe's writing usually was.

'You are sure they don't still suspect Lawrence?'

Lettice drifted towards us.

'I want the Fiat, Manning,' she said. 'Start her for me, will you?'

'Very good, Miss.'

He went towards a two-seater and lifted the bonnet.

Just a minute, Miss Protheroe,' said Slack. 'It's necessary that I should have a record of everybody's movements yesterday afternoon. No offence meant.'

Lettice stared at him.

'I never know the time of anything,' she said.

'I understand you went out soon after lunch yesterday.'

She nodded.

'Where to, please?'

'To play tennis.'

'Who with?'

'The Hartley Napiers.'

'At Much Benham?'

'Yes.'

'And you returned?'

'I don't know. I tell you I never know these things.'

'You returned,' I said, 'about seven-thirty.'

'That's right,' said Lettice. 'In the middle of the shemuzzle. Anne having fits and Griselda supporting her.'

'Thank you, Miss,' said the Inspector. 'That's all I want to know.'

'How queer,' said Lettice. 'It seems so uninteresting.'

She moved towards the Fiat.

The Inspector touched his forehead in a surreptitious manner.

'A bit wanting?' he suggested.

'Not in the least,' I said. 'But she likes to be thought so.'

'Well, I'm off to question the maids now.'

One cannot really like Slack, but one can admire his energy.

We parted company and I inquired of Reeves if I could see Mrs Protheroe.

'She is lying down, sir, at the moment.'

'Then I'd better not disturb her.'

'Perhaps if you would wait, sir, I know that Mrs Protheroe is anxious to see you. She was saying as much at luncheon.'

'I really can't say. You see, it was such an ordinary sound. I should be inclined to think it had been fired when we were in the studio. The sound would have been deadened and—and one would have noticed it less there.'

For other reasons than the sound being deadened, I thought to myself!

'I must ask Anne,' said Lawrence. 'She may remember. By the way, there seems to me to be one curious fact that needs explanation. Mrs Lestrang, the Mystery Lady of St Mary Mead, paid a visit to old Protheroe after dinner on Wednesday night. And nobody seems to have any idea what it was all about. Old Protheroe said nothing to either his wife or Lettice.'

'Perhaps the Vicar knows,' said Miss Marple.

Now how did the woman know that I had been to visit Mrs Lestrang that afternoon? The way she always knows things is uncanny.

I shook my head and said I could throw no light upon the matter.

'What does Inspector Slack think?' asked Miss Marple.

'He's done his best to bully the butler—but apparently the butler wasn't curious enough to listen at the door. So there it is—no one knows.'

'I expect someone overheard something, though, don't you?' said Miss Marple. 'I mean, somebody always *does*. I think that is where Mr Redding might find out something.'

'But Mrs Protheroe knows nothing.'

'I didn't mean Anne Protheroe,' said Miss Marple. 'I meant the women servants. They do so hate telling anything to the police. But a nice-looking young man—you'll excuse me, Mr Redding—and one who has been unjustly suspected—Oh! I'm sure they'd tell him at once.'

'I'll go and have a try this evening,' said Lawrence with vigour. 'Thanks for the hint, Miss Marple. I'll go after—well, after a little job the Vicar and I are going to do.'

It occurred to me that we had better be getting on with it. I said good-bye to Miss Marple and we entered the woods once more.

First we went up the path till we came to a new spot, where it certainly looked as though someone had left the path on the right-hand side. Lawrence explained that he had already followed this particular trail and found it led nowhere, but he added that we might as well try again. He might have been wrong.

It was, however, as he had said. After about ten or twelve yards, any sign of broken and trampled leaves petered out. It was from this spot that Lawrence had broken back towards the path to meet me earlier in the afternoon.

We emerged on the path again and walked a little farther along it. Again we came to a place where the bushes seemed disturbed. The signs were very slight but, I thought, unmistakable. This time the trail was more promising. By a devious course, it wound steadily nearer to the Vicarage. Presently we arrived at where the bushes grew thickly up to the wall. The wall is a high one and ornamented with fragments of broken bottles on the top. If anyone had placed a ladder against it, we ought to find traces of their passage.

We were working our way slowly along the wall when a sound came to our ears of a breaking twig. I pressed forward, forcing my way through a thick tangle of shrubs—and came face to face with Inspector Slack.

'So it's you,' he said. 'And Mr Redding. Now what do you think you two gentlemen are doing?'

Slightly crestfallen, we explained.

'Quite so,' said the Inspector. 'Not being the fools we're usually thought to be, I had the same idea myself. I've been here over an hour. Would you like to know something?'

'Yes,' I said meekly.

'Whoever murdered Colonel Protheroe didn't come this way to do it! There's not a sign either on this side of the wall, nor the other. Whoever murdered Colonel Protheroe came through the front door. There's no other way he could have come.'

'Impossible,' I cried.

'Why impossible? Your door stands open. Anyone's only got to walk in. They can't be seen from the kitchen. They know you're safely out of the way; they know Mrs Protheroe's in London; they know Mr Dennis is at a tennis party. Simple as A.B.C. And they don't need to go or come through the village. Just opposite the Vicarage gate is a public footpath and, from it, you can turn into these same woods and come out whichever way you choose. Unless Mrs Price Ridley were to come out of her front gate at that particular minute, it's all clear sailing. A great deal more so than climbing over walls.

'Now then, my lad,' said Slack, 'I want a little information from you.'

'Yes, sir,' stammered the chauffeur. 'Certainly, sir.'

If he had committed the murder himself he could not have been more alarmed.

'You took your master to the village yesterday?'

'Yes, sir.'

'What time was that?'

'Five-thirty.'

'Mrs Protheroe went too?'

'Yes, sir.'

'You went straight to the village?'

'Yes, sir.'

'You didn't stop anywhere on the way?'

'No, sir.'

'What did you do when you got there?'

'The Colonel got out and told me he wouldn't want the car again. He'd walk home. Mrs Protheroe had some shopping to do. The parcels were put in the car. Then she said that was all and I drove home.'

'Leaving her in the village?'

'Yes, sir.'

'What time was that?'

'A quarter past six, sir. A quarter past exactly.'

'Where did you leave her?'

'By the church, sir.'

'Had the Colonel mentioned at all where he was going?'

'He said something about having to see the vet—something to do with one of the horses.'

'I see. And you drove straight back here?'

'Yes, sir.'

'There are two entrances to Old Hall, by the South Lodge and by the North Lodge. I take it that going to the village you would go by the South Lodge?'

'Yes, sir, always.'

'And you came back the same way?'

'Yes, sir.'

'H'm. I think that's all. Ah! here's Miss Protheroe.'

'You really think that's likely?'

'Well, it fits the facts, sir. Why did a smart, well dressed lady come down to this quiet little hole? Why did she go and see him at that funny time of day? Why did she avoid seeing Mrs and Miss Protheroe? Yes, it all hangs together. Awkward for her to admit—blackmail's a punishable offence. But we'll get the truth out of her. For all we know it may have a very important bearing on the case. If Colonel Protheroe had some guilty secret in his life—something disgraceful—well, you can see for yourself what a field it opens up.'

I suppose it did.

'I've been trying to get the butler to talk. He might have overheard some of the conversation between Colonel Protheroe and Lestrangle. Butlers do sometimes. But he swears he hadn't the least idea of what the conversation was about. By the way, he got the sack through it. The Colonel went for him, being angry at his having let her in. The butler retorted by giving notice. Says he didn't like the place anyway, and had been thinking of leaving for some time.'

'Really?'

'So that gives us another person who had a grudge against the Colonel.'

'You don't seriously suspect the man—what's his name by the way?'

'His name's Reeves, and I don't say I do suspect him. What I say is, you never know. I don't like that soapy, oily manner of his.'

I wonder what Reeves would say of Inspector Slack's manner.

'I'm going to question the chauffeur now.'

'Perhaps, then,' I said, 'you'll give me a lift in your car. I want a short interview with Mrs Protheroe.'

'What about?'

'The funeral arrangements.'

'Oh!' Inspector Slack was slightly taken aback. 'The inquest's tomorrow, Saturday.'

'Just so. The funeral will probably be arranged for Tuesday.'

Inspector Slack seemed to be a little ashamed of himself for his brusqueness. He held out an olive branch in the shape of an invitation to be present at the interview with the chauffeur, Manning.

Manning was a nice lad, not more than twenty-five or -six years of age. He was inclined to be awed by the Inspector.

The side windows of the upper story of Mrs Price Ridley's house do overlook most of that wall. No, depend upon it, that's the way he came.'

It really seemed as though he must be right.

Chapter 16

As I went out, I ran into Haydock on the doorstep. He glanced sharply after Slack, who was just passing through the gate, and demanded: 'Has he been questioning her?'

'He's been civil, I hope?'

Civility, to my mind, is an art which Inspector Slack has never learnt, but I presumed that according to his own lights, civil he had been, and anyway I didn't want to upset Haydock any further. He was looking worried and upset as it was. So I said he had been quite civil.

Haydock nodded and passed on into the house, and I went on down the village street where I soon caught up with the Inspector. I fancy that he was walking slowly on purpose. Much as he dislikes me, he is not the man to let dislike stand in the way of acquiring any useful information.

'Do you know anything about the lady?' he asked me point-blank.

I said I knew nothing whatever.

'She's never said anything about why she came here to live?'

'No.'

'Yet you go and see her?'

'It is one of my duties to call on my parishioners,' I replied, evading to remark that I had been sent for.

'H'm, I suppose it is.' He was silent for a minute or two and then, unable to resist discussing his recent failure, he went on, 'Fishy business, it looks to me.'

'You think so?'

'If you ask me, I say 'blackmail'. Seems funny, when you think of what Colonel Protheroe was always supposed to be. But there, you never can tell. He wouldn't be the first churchwarden who'd led a double life.'

Faint remembrances of Miss Marple's remarks on the same subject floated through my mind.

‘Well,’ he said, extricating himself with dignity, ‘don’t say I haven’t warned you, that’s all. Good afternoon, Madam, and mind you, we’re going to get at the truth.’

He departed. Mrs Lestrangle rose and held out her hand.

‘I am going to send you away—yes, it is better so. You see, it is too late for advice now. I have chosen my part.’

She repeated, in a rather forlorn voice:

‘I have chosen my part.’

Chapter 17

INSPECTOR Slack came round to see me the following morning. He is, I think, thawing towards me. In time, he may forget the incident of the clock.

‘Well, sir,’ he greeted me. ‘I’ve traced that telephone call that you received.’

‘Indeed?’ I said eagerly.

‘It’s rather odd. It was put through from the North Lodge of Old Hall. Now that Lodge is empty; the lodgekeepers have been pensioned off, and the new lodgekeepers aren’t in yet. The place was empty and convenient—a window at the back was open. No finger prints on the instrument itself—it had been wiped clean. That’s suggestive.’

‘How do you mean?’

‘I mean that it shows that call was put through deliberately to get you out of the way. Therefore the murder was carefully planned in advance. If it had been just a harmless practical joke, the fingerprints wouldn’t have been wiped off so carefully.’

‘No, I see that.’

‘It also shows that the murderer was well acquainted with Old Hall and its surroundings. It wasn’t Mrs Protheroe who put that call through. I’ve accounted for every moment of her time that afternoon. There are half a dozen servants who can swear that she was at home up till five-thirty. Then the car came round and drove Colonel Protheroe and her to the village. The Colonel went to see Quinton, the vet, about one of the horses. Mrs Protheroe did some ordering at the grocer’s and at the fish shop, and from there came straight down the back lane where Miss Marple saw her. All the shops agree she carried no handbag with her. The old lady was right.’

‘She usually is,’ I said mildly.

‘And Miss Protheroe was over at Much Benham at 5.30.’

‘Quite so,’ I said. ‘My nephew was there too.’

‘That disposes of her. The maids seem all right—a bit hysterical and upset, but what can you expect? Of course, I’ve got my eye on the butler—what with giving notice and all. But I don’t think he knows anything about it.’

‘Your inquiries seem to have had rather a negative result, Inspector.’

‘They do and they do not, sir. There’s one very queer thing has turned up—quite unexpectedly, I may say.’

‘Yes?’

‘You remember the fuss that Mrs Price Ridley, who lives next door to you, was kicking up yesterday morning? About being rung up on the telephone?’

‘Yes?’ I said.

‘Well we traced the call just to calm her—and where on this earth do you think it was put through from?’

‘A call office?’ I hazarded.

‘No, Mr Clement. That call was put through from Mr Lawrence Redding’s cottage.’

‘What?’ I exclaimed, surprised.

‘Yes. A bit odd, isn’t it? Mr Redding had nothing to do with it. At that time, 6.35, he was on his way to the Blue Boar with Dr Stone, in full view of the village. But there it is. Suggestive, eh? Someone walked into that empty cottage and used the telephone. Who was it? That’s two queer telephone calls in one day. Makes you think there’s some connection between them. I’ll eat my hat if they weren’t both put through by the same person.’

‘But with what object?’

‘Well, that’s what we’ve got to find out. There seems no particular point in the second one, but there must be a point somewhere. And you see the significance? Mr Redding’s house used to telephone from. Mr Redding’s pistol. All throwing suspicion on Mr Redding.’

‘It would be more to the point to have put through the *first* call from his house,’ I objected.

‘Ah! But I’ve been thinking that out. What did Mr Redding do most afternoons? He went up to Old Hall and painted Miss Protheroe. And from his cottage, he’d go on his motor bicycle, passing through the North Gate. Now you see the point of the call being put through from there. *The murderer*

‘In fact, I have to take your word about everything.’

‘It does seem rather like it,’ she agreed, still with the same smiling calm.

Inspector Slack grew very red.

‘This is a serious matter, Mrs Lestrangle. I want the truth—’ He banged his fist down on a table, ‘and I mean to get it.’

Mrs Lestrangle said nothing at all.

‘Don’t you see, Madam, that you’re putting yourself in a very fishy position? Still Mrs Lestrangle said nothing.

‘You’ll be required to give evidence at the inquest.’

‘Yes.’

Just the monosyllable. Unemphatic, uninterested. The Inspector altered his tactics.

‘You were acquainted with Colonel Protheroe?’

‘Yes, I was acquainted with him.’

‘Well acquainted?’

There was a pause before she said:

‘I had not seen him for several years.’

‘You were acquainted with Mrs Protheroe?’

‘No.’

‘You’ll excuse me, but it was a very unusual time to make a call.’

‘Not from my point of view.’

‘What do you mean by that?’

She said clearly and distinctly:

‘I wanted to see Colonel Protheroe alone. I did not want to see Mrs Protheroe or Miss Protheroe. I considered this the best way of accomplishing my objective.’

‘Why didn’t you want to see Mrs or Miss Protheroe?’

‘That, Inspector, is my business.’

‘Then you refuse to say more?’

‘Absolutely.’

Inspector Slack rose.

‘You’ll be putting yourself in a nasty position, Madam, if you’re not careful. All this looks bad—it looks very bad.’

She laughed. I could have told Inspector Slack that this was not the kind of woman who is easily frightened.